

Measuring the Ideology-Policy Gap

Empirical Evidence from Argentina's 2023 Election

Sebastián Freille

Instituto de Economía y Finanzas (UNC)

Collaborators: Rubio, M; Jaroszewski, V.; Hofmann, R.; Albarracin, C.; Prazoni, G.;
Larovere, S.; Seia, L; Bachiglione, C.; Balbo, S.

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Outline

- The Puzzle
- Research Design
- Main Results
- Interpretation
- Limitations & Next Steps
- Conclusion
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The Puzzle

A Familiar Paradox

90% of Argentines reject cuts to public health and education. Yet Milei won promising exactly that.

The Standard Model Fails

Median Voter Theorem predicts convergence and policy-based voting.

Reality:

- Increasing polarization
- “Identity” voting
- Apparent contradictions between beliefs and behavior

Ideology vs. Policy: A Distinction

	Ideology	Policy
Nature	Abstract, symbolic	Concrete, operational
Example	“Smaller government is better”	“Privatize Aerolíneas Argentinas”
Literature	Converse (1964); Ellis & Stimson (2012)	Alesina et al. (2020)

Research Design

Two Parallel Questionnaires

Ideology Survey

- 17 items (8 economic, 9 social)
- Abstract, identitarian language
- *“Countries with smaller governments tend to be more successful”*

Policy Survey

- 17 parallel items
- Concrete, operational language
- *“Privatize Aerolíneas, BNA, and ARSAT”,
“Eliminate Tarjeta Alimentar and use those funds to reduce taxes on PyMEs”*

Sample: Two Survey Waves

	2024 Wave	2025 Wave	Combined
N	25	23	48
Milei voters	15	19	34
Massa voters	4	3	7
Blank/No vote	6	1	7

- FCE-UNC students surveyed around 2023 election
- 2025 wave includes **self-reported political identities** (16 categories)
- Pooled analysis with year controls

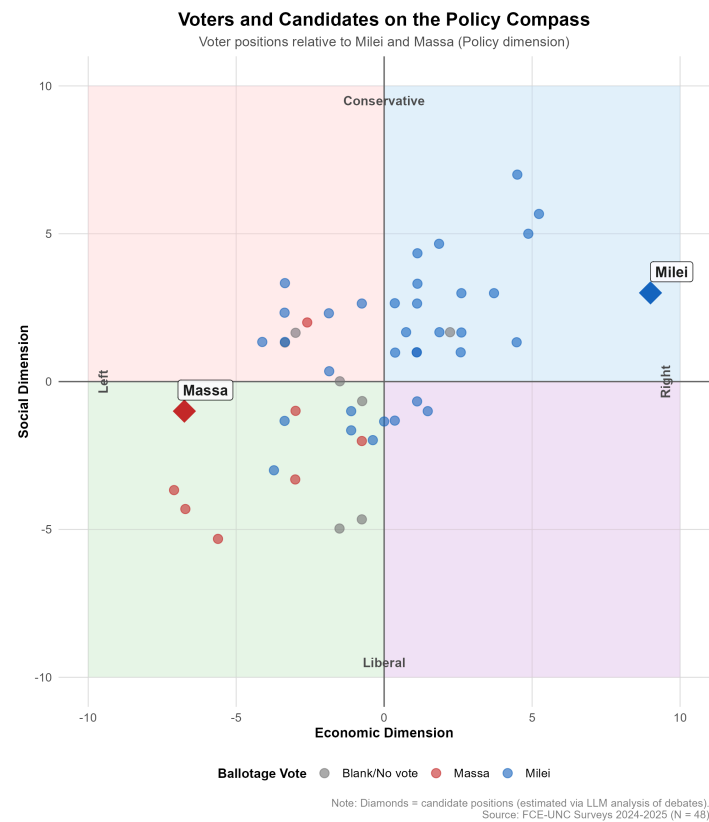
Candidate Positions via LLM

We locate candidates on the same compass using **LLM-based inference**:

1. Fed Gemini 2.5 Pro transcripts of presidential debates
2. Asked it to answer *our two surveys* as each candidate –we “asked” all 34 questions to each candidate
3. Required verbatim quotes as justification

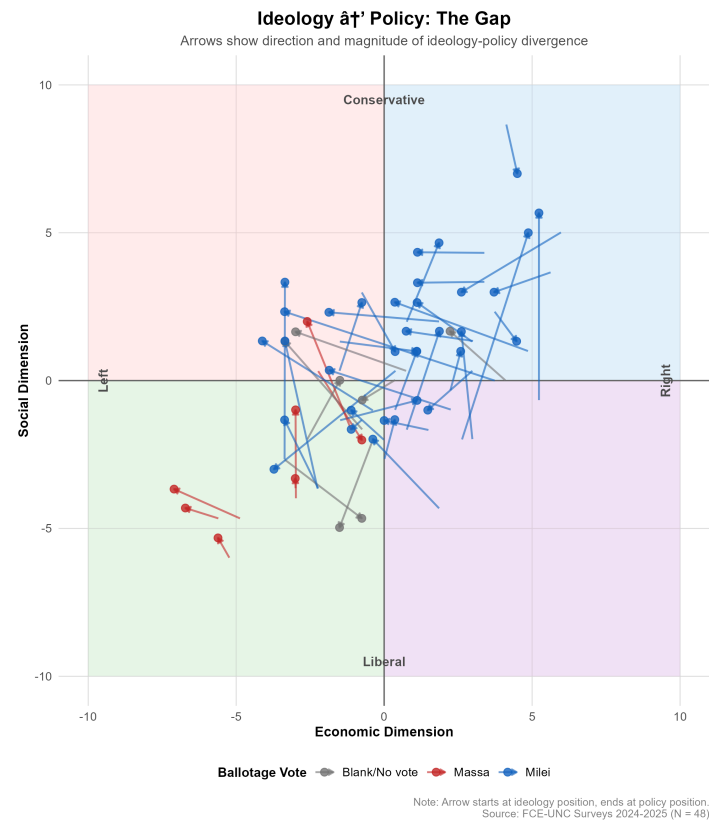
Main Results

The Political Compass: Where Voters Stand



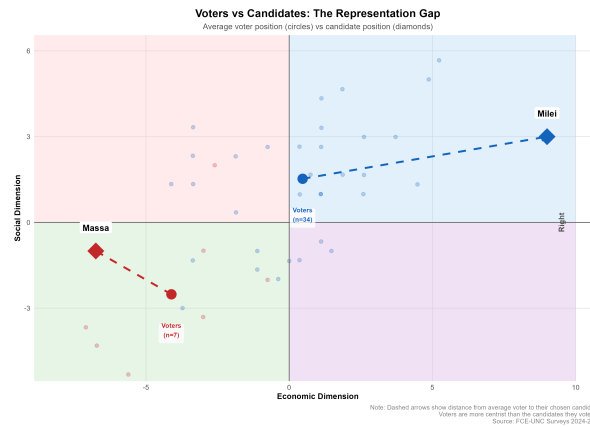
Policy positions with candidate locations. Blue = Milei voters, Red = Massa voters.

The Gap: Ideology → Policy



Arrows show direction and magnitude of each voter’s ideology-policy gap.

The Representation Paradox



Voters are systematically more centrist than the candidates they vote for. Dashed arrows show distance to “own” candidate.

Key Finding #1: The Gap Predicts Voting

Logistic regression: Distance to candidates in ideology and policy space

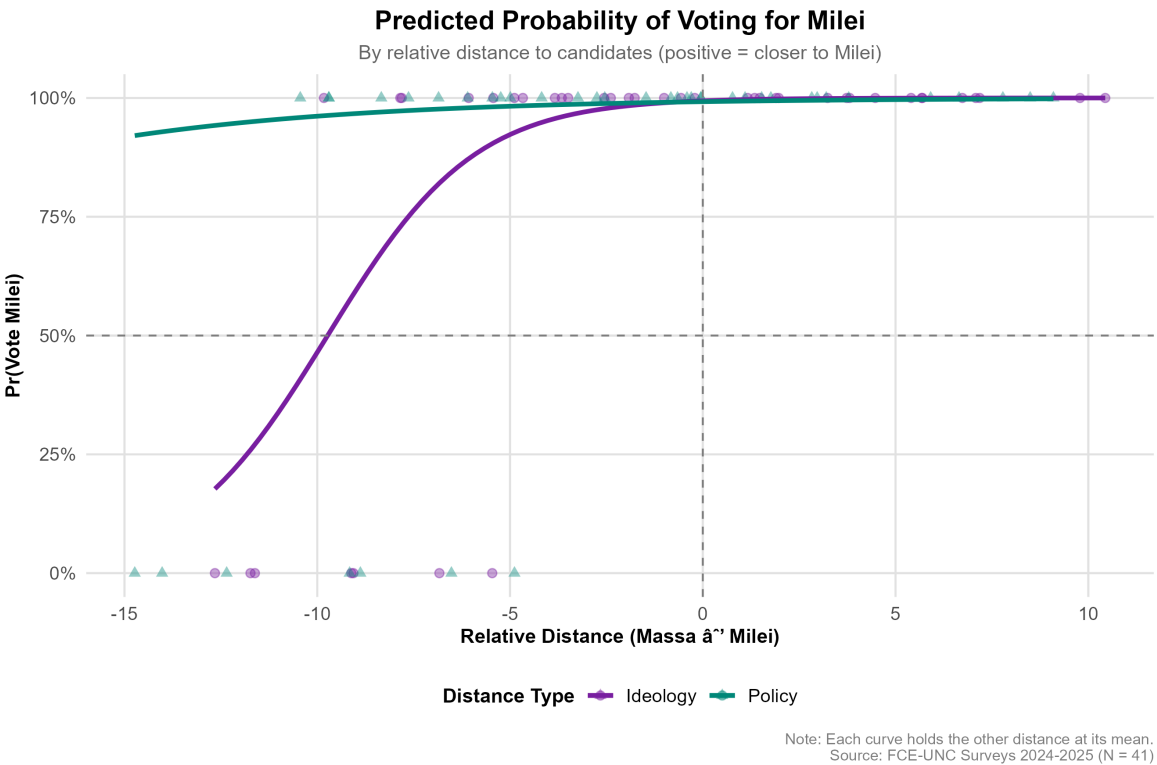
Model	Accuracy	N
Ideology distance only	58.5%	41
Policy distance only	48.8%	41
Logistic (ideology)	92.7%	41
Logistic (policy)	90.2%	41
Full model (ideology + policy)	92.7%	41

The Econometric Model

We transform the **probabilistic voting model** into a spatial loss function:

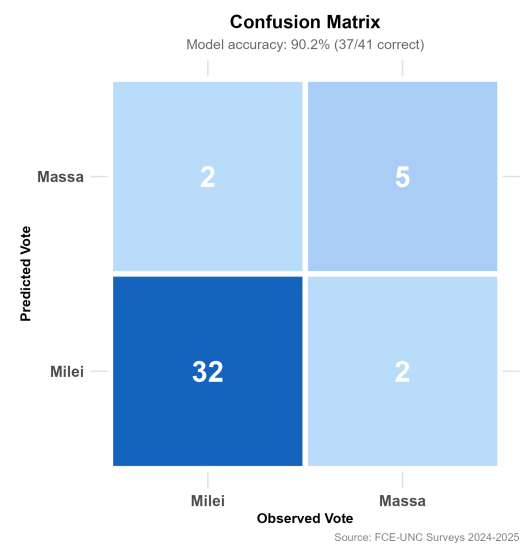
$$L^{ij} = \alpha \sqrt{(\sigma^{ij} - \sigma^A)^2} + \beta \sqrt{(q^{ij} - q^A)^2}$$

Predicted Probabilities: The S-Curve



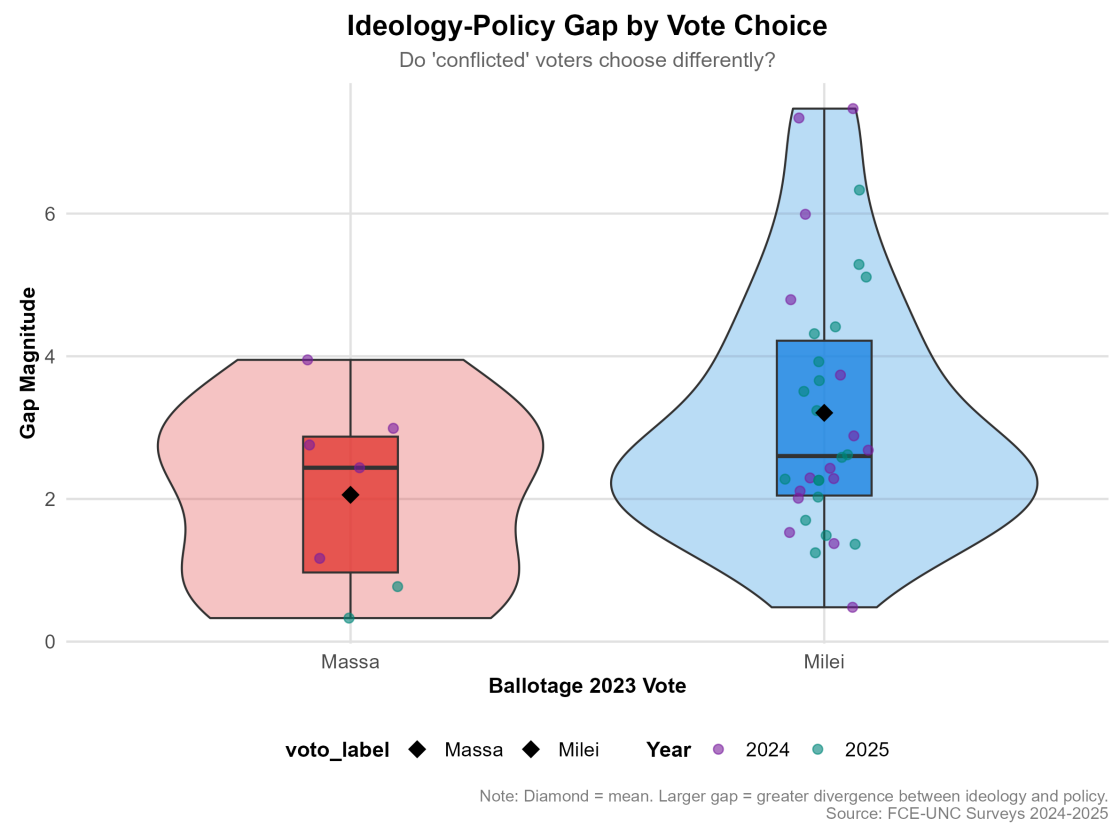
Probability of voting Milei as a function of ideological and policy distance differentials. Steeper curves = stronger predictive power.

Model Validation: Confusion Matrix



Confusion matrix showing predicted vs. observed votes. 38 of 41 votes correctly classified (92.7% accuracy).

Key Finding #2: Milei Voters Have Larger Gaps

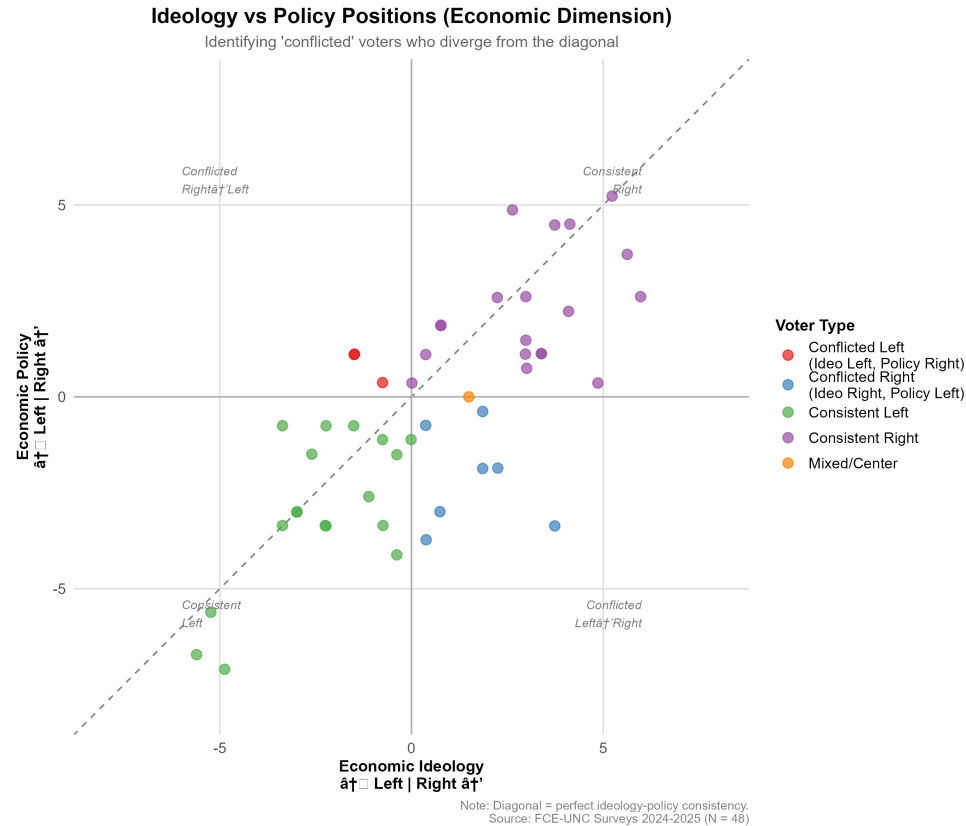


Gap magnitude by vote choice. Milei voters show systematically larger ideology-policy divergence.

Quantifying the Gap Asymmetry

Vote	Mean Gap	Median Gap	SD
Milei	3.21	2.60	1.77
Massa	2.06	2.44	1.32

Key Finding #3: Voter Typology



Four types of voters based on gap direction. “Conflicted” voters show ideology-policy mismatch.

The Four Types

Type	Description	% of Sample
Consistent Right	Right ideology, right policy	39%
Consistent Left	Left ideology, left policy	17%
Conflicted Right	Right ideology, <i>left</i> policy	27%
Conflicted Left	Left ideology, <i>right</i> policy	17%

Interpretation

What Have We Learned?

Connecting to the Literature

Finding	Related Work
Ideology-policy gap exists	Ellis & Stimson (2012); Claassen et al. (2015)
Gap varies by partisanship	Achen & Bartels (2016); Mason (2018)
Voters more centrist than candidates	Fiorina (2017); elite polarization
Policy misperceptions	Alesina, Stantcheva & Teso (2018)

Limitations & Next Steps

Limitations

1. **Sample:** University students (FCE-UNC), not representative
2. **Single election:** Argentina 2023 (high-stakes, polarized)
3. **LLM validation:** Candidate positions need expert cross-validation

Research Agenda

1. **Scale up:** Online panels, cross-university, representative samples
2. **Identity mechanisms:** 2025 wave has 16 identity categories—analysis in progress
3. **Panel design:** Track same individuals across elections

Conclusion

Summary

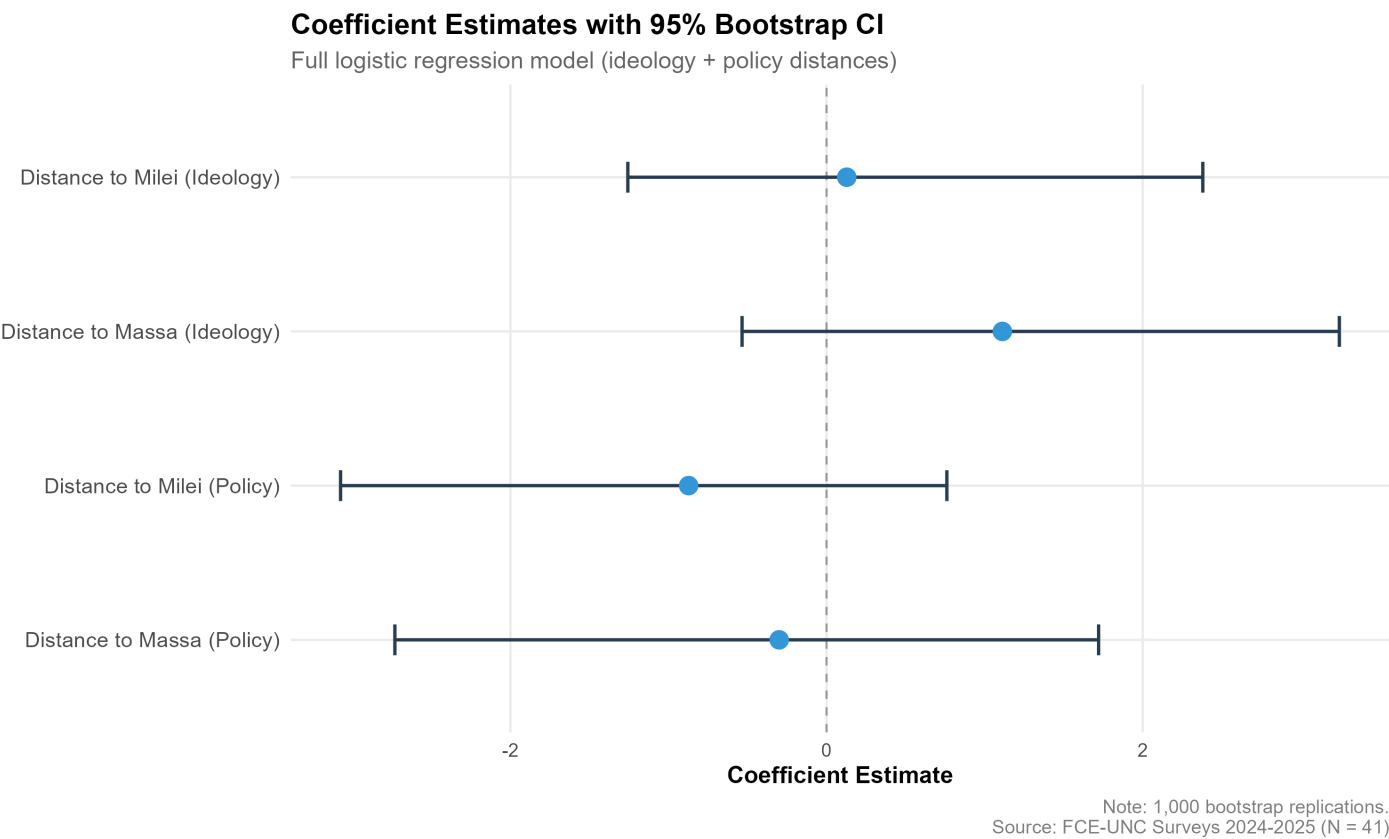
1. **Methodology:** Separate ideology from policy using parallel questionnaires; locate voters and candidates in 2D space
2. **Main finding:** The ideology-policy gap predicts voting with 92.7% accuracy (robust to cross-validation)
3. **Substantive insight:** ~44% of voters are “conflicted”—Milei voters especially show large gaps
4. **Implication:** Voters may choose candidates based on *identity* despite disagreeing on *policy*

The Takeaway

Voters don't vote their interests. They don't even vote their stated beliefs. They vote the *gap* between who they think they are and what they actually want.

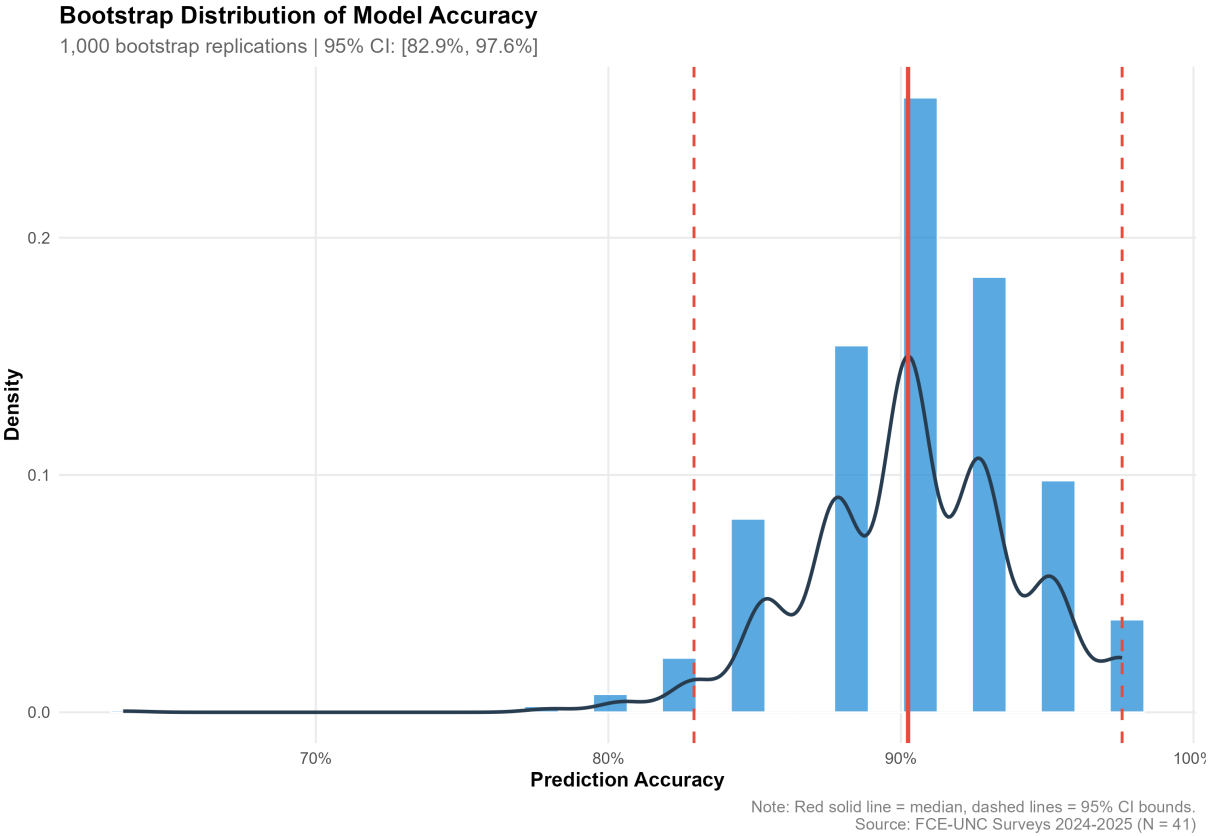
Appendix

A1: Full Regression Results



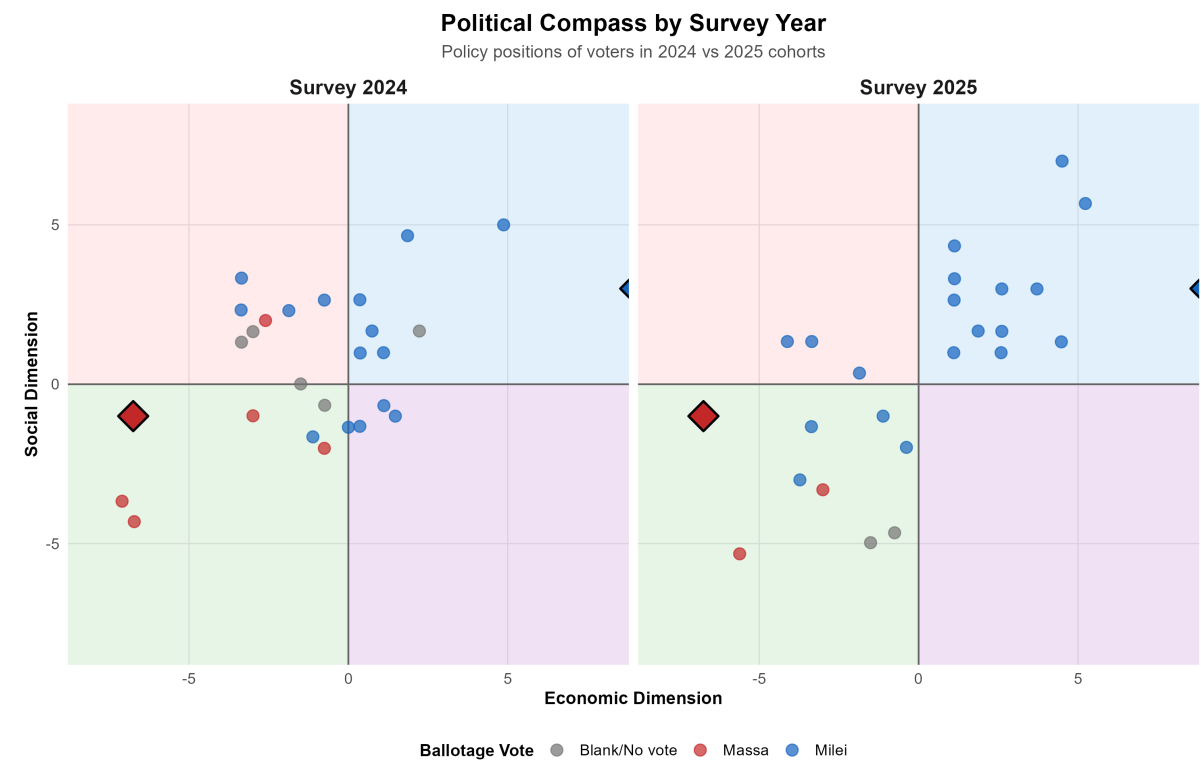
Coefficient estimates with 95% bootstrap confidence intervals.

A2: Bootstrap Accuracy Distribution



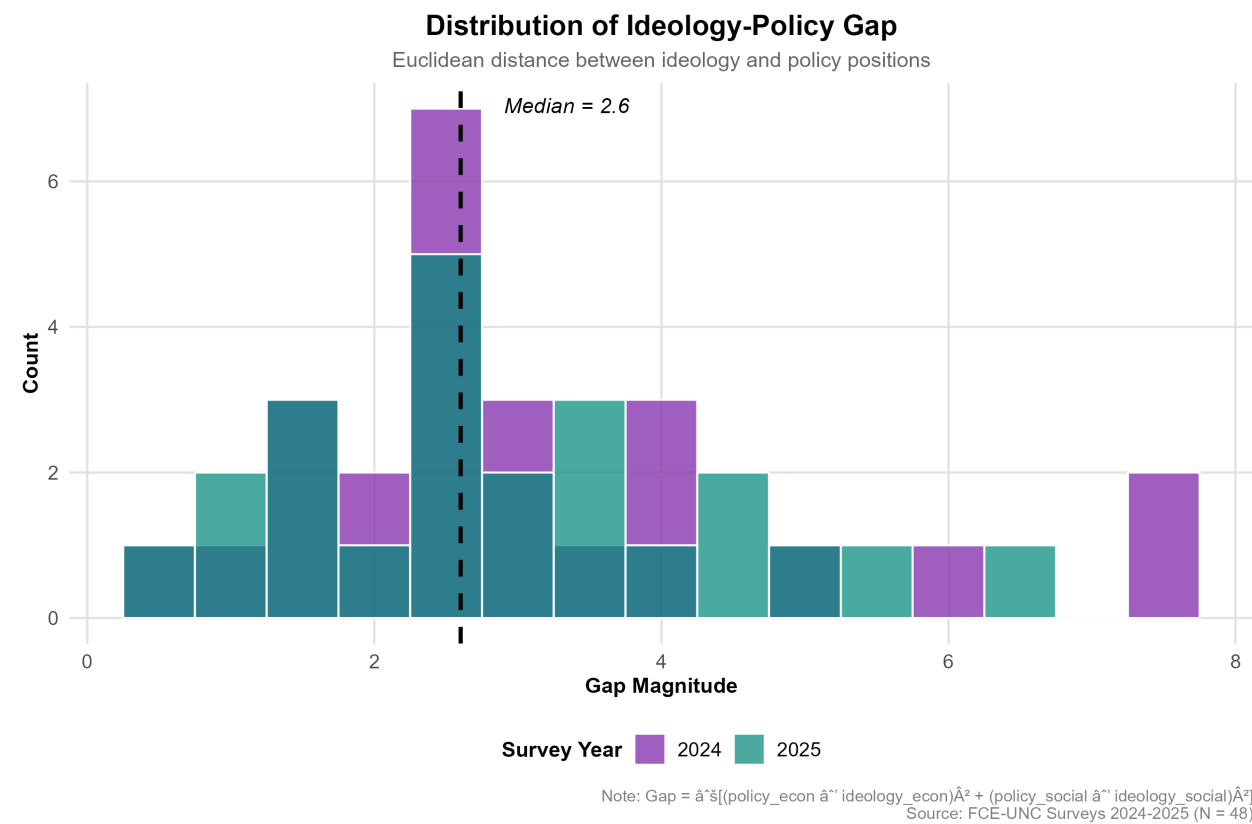
1,000 bootstrap replications. 95% CI: [82.9%, 97.6%].

A3: Compass by Survey Year



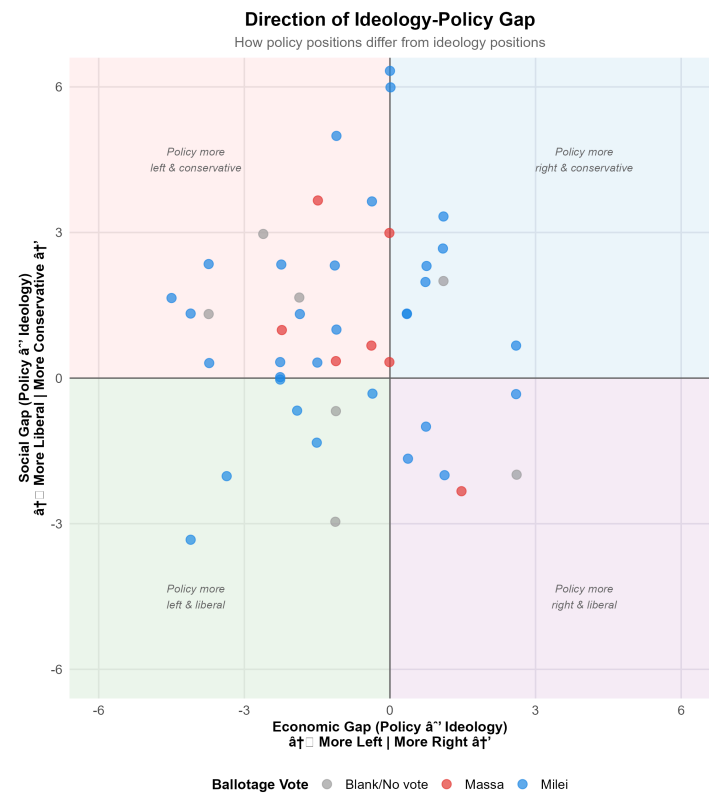
Policy positions faceted by 2024 vs 2025 cohort. Results stable across waves.

A4: Gap Distribution



Distribution of ideology-policy gap magnitude across all voters.

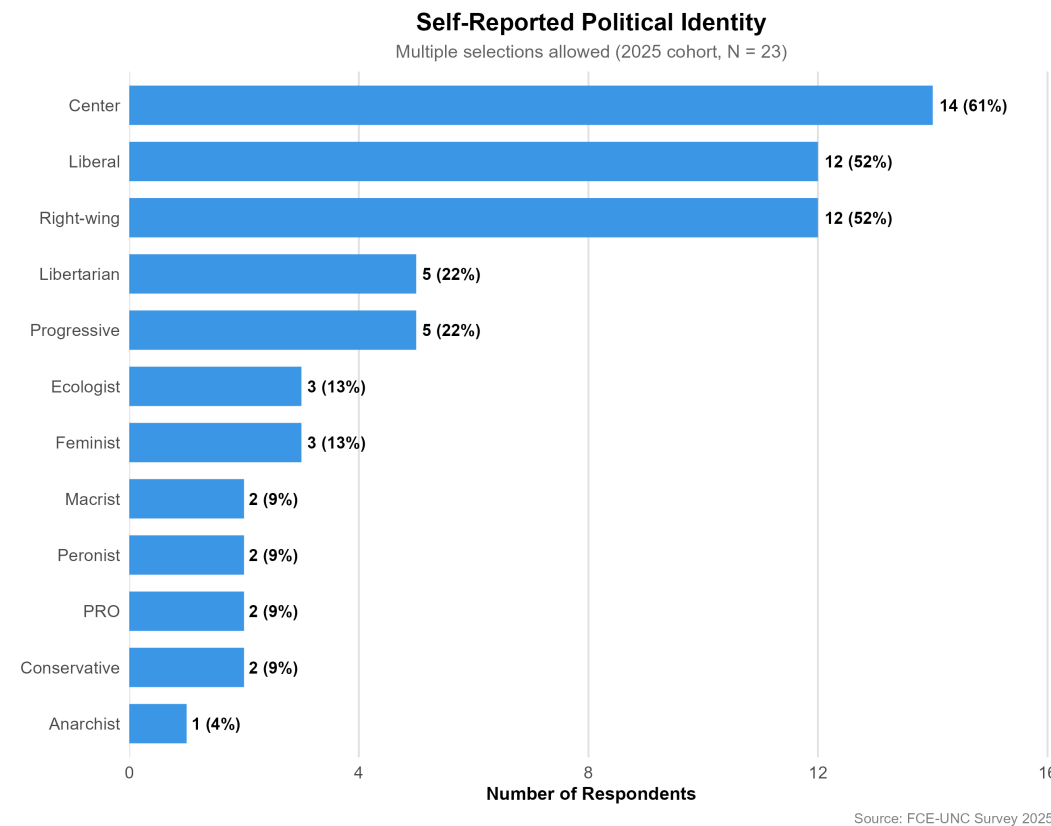
A5: Gap Direction Patterns



Note: Points at origin = ideology matches policy.
Source: FCE-UNC Surveys 2024-2025 (N = 48)

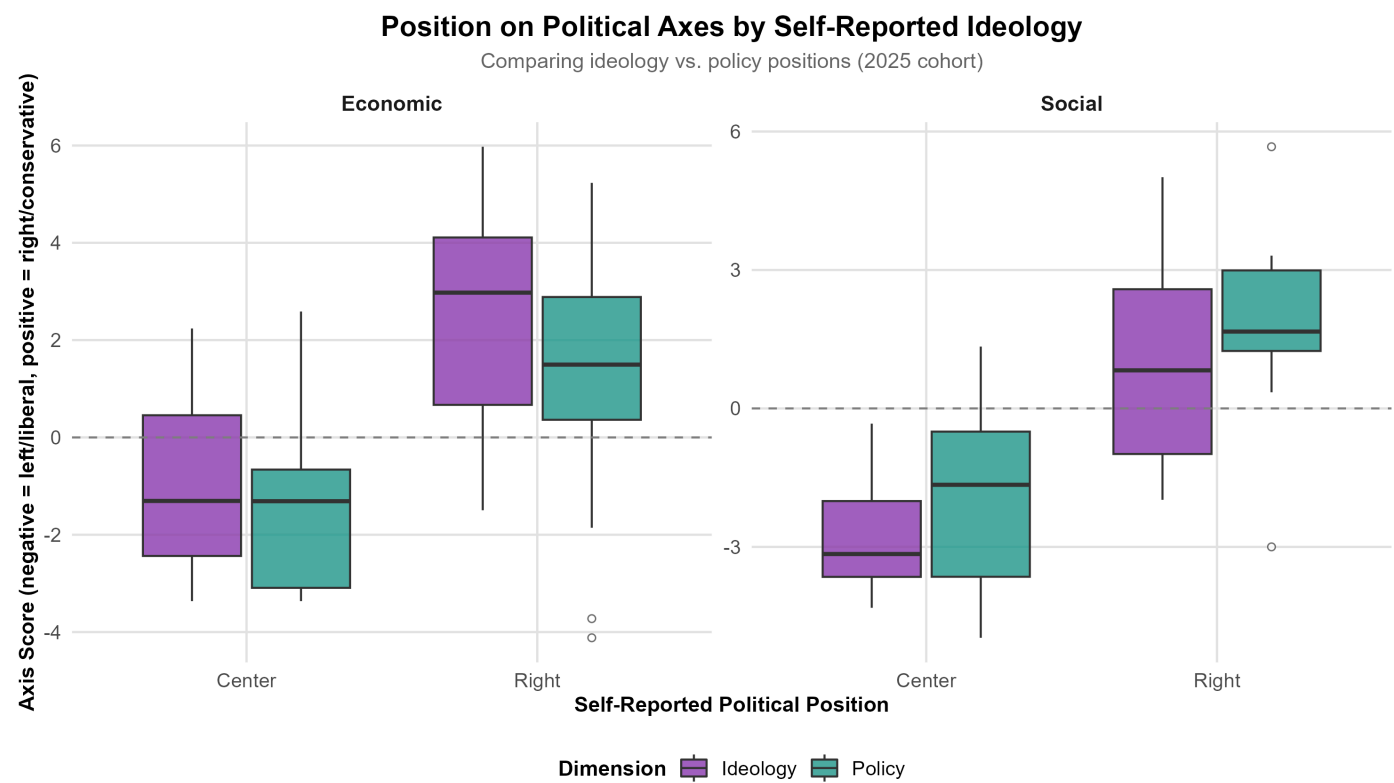
Scatterplot of economic vs. social gap direction. Quadrants show conflict types.

A6: Political Identity Distribution (2025 Wave)



Self-reported political identities. Multiple selections allowed.

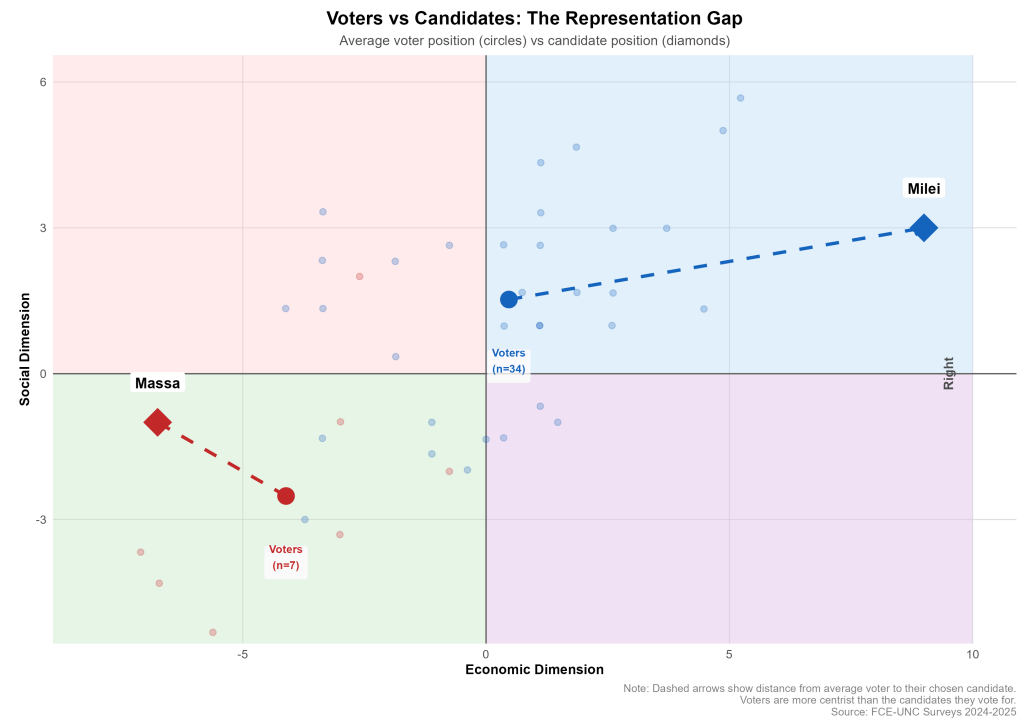
A7: Axes by Political Identity



Source: FCE-UNC Survey 2025

Ideology and policy positions grouped by self-reported identity.

A8: Voter Centroids vs. Candidates



Average position of Milei and Massa voters vs. candidate positions. Dashed lines show distance to “own” candidate.

A9: Model Accuracy Comparison

Model	Correct	Total	Accuracy
Ideology-based (nearest candidate)	24	41	58.5%
Policy-based (nearest candidate)	20	41	48.8%
Combined (average distance)	22	41	53.7%
Logistic regression (ideology)	38	41	92.7%
Logistic regression (policy)	37	41	90.2%
Logistic regression (full)	38	41	92.7%

A10: Descriptive Statistics by Vote

Group	N	Econ Ideo	Social Ideo	Econ Policy	Social Policy
Milei	34	+1.54	+0.22	+0.47	+1.53
Massa	7	-3.57	-3.47	-4.11	-2.52
Overall	41	+0.67	-0.41	-0.31	+0.84

A11: LLM Methodology

We used **Google Gemini 2.5 Pro** to locate candidates:

1. Fed transcript of first presidential debate (Oct 1, 2023)
2. Asked model to answer our survey *as each candidate*
3. Required verbatim quotes as justification
4. Cross-validated with CNE platforms and interviews

A12: Survey Instruments

Los ricos deben pagar relativamente más impuestos que los pobres
Las medidas de restricción de la circulación y aislamiento obligatorio durante la pandemia fueron excesivas y un atropello a la libertad individual
El aborto, cuando no esté amenazada la vida de la madre, siempre debería ser ilegal
El Estado no debería obligar a vacunar a los niños
El peronismo es el responsable de arruinar nuestro país en los últimos años

Ideology questionnaire

Privatizar Aerolíneas Argentinas, el Banco Nación y ARSAT
La política de Etiquetado Frontal (octógonos) en el mercado alimentario
El gobierno debe limitar los viajes a Brasil en enero de 2025 para evitar la introducción de Zika y Chikungunya en Argentina
Reducir la edad de imputabilidad a los 14 años de edad
El Estado debe incluir la vacuna del Covid en el Calendario Obligatorio de Vacunación

Policy questionnaire

A13: Year Stability Check

Year	Accuracy	N
2024	100.0%	20
2025	100.0%	21
Pooled	92.7%	41

Model performs well in both cohorts separately.

A14: Alternative Distance Metrics

Metric	Accuracy
Euclidean distance	92.7%
Manhattan distance	90.2%

Results robust to distance specification.